

HM412 World Literature in Short Fiction

(Winter 2026)

Instructor: Satvik Gupta, 3204, Faculty Block-3

Course Placement: HASS Elective/Open Elective, B.Tech. (Semester - VI)

Course format: 3 Lecture hours

Course content: “The experience of reading world literature is a form of travel—a mode of cultural encounter that presents us with languages, cultural norms, customs and ideas that may be unfamiliar to us, even strange. As readers, each time we begin to read a new work, we put ourselves in the role of a traveller in a foreign land, trying to understand its practices and values and hoping to feel, to some degree and in some way, connected to and welcome among the people we meet there” (*The Norton Anthology of World Literature*).

Following an introductory discourse on the history and overarching tradition of world literature, this course will limit its scope to the texts produced during the nineteenth and twentieth centuries. This period of world history bore witness to radical change and profound upheaval, marked by world wars, the fall of empires, the rise of new ideologies, and unprecedented technological advancements. This course, therefore, explores how authors across the globe utilised the short story form to capture the anxieties and transformations of the world around them. The readings are organised into four thematic modules that position the ‘modern individual’ against the bureaucratic city, the legacy of the empire, linguistic labyrinths and the frailty of borders. Through this eclectic mix of narratives, learners are expected to cultivate a deeper appreciation for the short story form as a global medium of artistic expression.

Note: This course demands rigorous reading. Students will be required to read all the primary texts mentioned below. Furthermore, the attendance benchmark for this course is 60%; attendance below this threshold will result in a reduction of the grade.

Course Objectives:

This course aims to:

- Situate key works of short fiction within their broader historical and cultural contexts.
- Explore the development of major literary movements through representative texts.
- Cultivate skills in close reading and critical analysis.
- Present a diverse selection of short fiction from various global traditions to highlight the richness of modern world literature.

Course Syllabus:

Primary readings are the essential texts that will be discussed during the semester. Additional readings will be referenced in the classroom, but they aren't included in the overall evaluation and are provided here for your convenience and reference. All the texts mentioned below will be provided to the students before each lecture.

Introduction:

David Damrosch, "Goethe Coins a Phrase" in *What Is World Literature* (2003).

Module One: Modernity and the Bureaucratic City

Nikolai Gogol, "The Overcoat" (Russia, 1842)

Herman Melville, "Bartleby, the Scrivener" (USA, 1853)

Module Two: Empire and the Private Sphere

Rabindranath Tagore, "Punishment" (India, 1892)

Katherine Mansfield, "The Garden Party" (New Zealand, 1922)

Doris Lessing, "The Old Chief Mshlanga" (Southern Rhodesia/Zimbabwe, 1951)

Module Three: Labyrinths of Meaning – Language and Translation

Ryūnosuke Akutagawa, "In a Bamboo Grove" (Japan, 1922)

Jorge Luis Borges, "The Garden of Forking Paths" (Argentina, 1941)

Vladimir Nabokov, "Signs and Symbols" (USA/Russia, 1948)

Module Four: Revolution, Partition, and the Border

Lu Xun, "Diary of a Madman" (China, 1918)

Saadat Hasan Manto, "Toba Tek Singh" (India, 1955)

Albert Camus, "The Guest" (France/Algeria, 1957)

Additional Readings:

This list provides suggestions for further reading beyond the syllabus of this course:

- Ivan Turgenev, "Bezhin Meadow" (Russia, 1852)
- Guy de Maupassant, "The Necklace" (France, 1884)
- Leo Tolstoy, "The Death of Ivan Ilyich" (Russia, 1886)

- Anton Chekhov, “The Lady with the Dog” (Russia, 1899)
- Thomas Mann, “Death in Venice” (Germany, 1912)
- James Joyce, “The Dead” (Ireland, 1914)
- Premchand, “The Road to Salvation” (India, 1924)
- Ernest Hemingway, “Hills Like White Elephants” (USA, 1927)
- William Faulkner, “A Rose for Emily” (USA, 1930)
- Shirley Jackson, “The Lottery” (USA, 1948)
- Julio Cortázar, “House Taken Over” (Argentina, 1951)
- Flannery O’Connor, “A Good Man Is Hard to Find” (USA, 1953)
- Hanan al-Shaykh, “The Women's Swimming Pool” (Lebanon, 1982)
- Arunava Sinha (editor), *The Greatest Indian Stories Ever Told* (2023)
- Arjun Appadurai, *Modernity at Large: Cultural Dimensions of Globalization* (1996)

Evaluation plan:

1. Assignment/Quiz: 30%
2. Classroom Presentations: 20%
3. Group Activities: 20%
4. End Semester Exam: 30%

Course Outcomes:

Upon successful completion of this course, students will be able to:

- Connect literary works to their broader historical and cultural contexts.
- Compare and contrast literary styles and movements, such as Modernism, Realism, Magical Realism, and Postcolonialism.
- Develop informed and nuanced arguments about global literary traditions.
- Cultivate an appreciation for diverse literary voices and styles from around the world.

P1	P2	P3	P4	P5	P6	P7	P8	P9	P10	P11	P12
			X		X	X	X	X	X		X

Tentative Lecture Distribution

Sl. No.	Description		No. of Lectures
1	Introduction to World Literature		5
	1.1	What is world literature?	2
	1.2	History of world literature	3

2	Module One: Modernity and the Bureaucratic City		8
	2.1	Modernity - The precursor to Modernism	2
	2.2	Nikolai Gogol, “The Overcoat”	3
	2.3	Herman Melville, “Bartleby, the Scrivener”	3
3	Module Two: Empire and the Private Sphere		9
	3.1	Rabindranath Tagore, “Punishment”	3
	3.2	Katherine Mansfield, “The Garden Party”	3
	3.3	Doris Lessing, “The Old Chief Mshlanga”	3
4	Module Three: Labyrinths of Meaning – Language and Translation		11
	4.1	Introduction to Postmodernism	2
	4.2	Ryūnosuke Akutagawa, “In a Bamboo Grove”	3
	4.3	Jorge Luis Borges, “The Garden of Forking Paths”	3
	4.4	Vladimir Nabokov, “Signs and Symbols”	3
5	Module Four: Revolution, Partition, and the Border		9
	5.1	Lu Xun, “Diary of a Madman”	3
	5.2	Saadat Hasan Manto, “Toba Tek Singh”	3
	5.3	Albert Camus, “The Guest”	3
Total Lectures			42